

Haul Out the Old Cliches, It's Time to Shoot an Author Photo

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ON one of my first writing gigs in the late 1960's, I was sent out on assignment with a photographer who told me that there are just four basic cliches of portrait photography. If it's a woman, he explained, pose her in front of a body of water or a tree. Men are easier. Just stick them in front of a bookshelf, or pose them in the classic lounge lizard chin-in-the-hand position.

A stroll through any bookshop raises the suspicion that very little progress has been made in the world of big-time portrait photography cliches over the past 25 years -- at least when it comes to author photos. John Updike, Bernie Siegel, David Halberstam, Dominick Dunne, Barbara Grizzuti Harrison and Caryl Phillips all lean forward uncomfortably, their chins or cheeks supported by a fist or hand. (Presumably their own hands, but who knows?) They all look like failed lounge acts appearing at your local piano bar. Mr. Updike appears ready to launch into an angst-laden version of "Sometimes When We Touch."

Tom Wicker, Thomas Powers and Saul Bellow, lest we miss the point that they are writers, or at least somehow associated with books, have all positioned themselves in front of bookshelves.

There's a nice stream rushing by Ann Druyan and her husband and co-author, Carl Sagan, on "Shadows of Forgotten Ancestors." Ms. Druyan looks sensitive. Mr. Sagan looks a bit queasy, no doubt longing for a bookcase or a place to rest his weary chin. Even the stylish and innovative dust jacket protecting "The Secret History" shows its author, Donna Tartt, standing in front of a whole gaggle of trees. (Or forest, if you want to get technical.)

If there are any new cliches, it's simply the gender mixing of the old ones. Al Gore leans against a tree. He looks as sensitive as Ms. Druyan. "Earth in the Balance" is about ecology, so I guess you wouldn't want to see Mr. Gore grilling a spotted owl. Annie Dillard demonstrates her versatility on the covers of "Teaching a Stone to Talk" and "The Writing Life." On the first, she supports her left cheek in hand, and on the second her right cheek, while grasping a pen in the

supporting hand. (Get it? A pen, "The Writing Life"?) On the jacket of "The English Patient" the novelist Michael Ondaatje adds a twist by leaning forward, his (bearded) chin in hand, with what looks like a waterfall or shrubbery in the distance. I can't be sure. Maybe it's just a very wet or weedy bookcase.

Henry Petroski pulls out all the stops on "The Pencil." He's got bookcases behind him, a desk in front of him, a pencil in hand and, for the benefit of the denser reader, there's also a pencil sharpener.

In short, author photos are awful. Is there something going on here beyond bad taste? Are publishers trying to make some sort of point? George Lange, a portrait photographer who shoots an occasional book jacket, has become convinced that "people only write books because they need a new passport photo every five years." It's not their fault, he told me. "Authors are interesting subjects, and great photographers, such as Irving Penn, have taken great photographs of authors. But these rarely show up on jackets because the editors want it very straight. They don't want the pictures to be too revealing."

WHAT is it they do want? Some of the publishing people we contacted refused to talk on the record about the subject. They would at first feign indifference, saying they would prefer to talk about "good books rather than book jackets," or something lofty like that. Then they would insist on going off the record and proceed to harangue me endlessly about their obviously very profound feelings about author portraits. I am now in the possession of many rules and techniques that have helped create the worst photographs in America. Fortunately, I've been sworn to secrecy.

One of the exceptions was Victoria Wilson, a vice president and associate publisher at Knopf. "There are no rules," she said, then immediately reversed herself. "Well, I have one rule: No cats." She paused again. "I broke that rule with Diane Johnson's 'Natural Opium.' I made an exception because the book is a collection of travel pieces. And there she was wearing a pith helmet. The cat

was in a tree." Ms. Wilson, like other editors interviewed, said she often tries to find a side of the author that might not be apparent in her writing. On "The Tale of the Body Thief," she used a photo of Anne Rice taken by her sister. Ms. Wilson says the photograph shows Ms. Rice relaxed and portrays a "sweetness" that people don't usually see in the novelist. "There are no rules," Ms. Wilson repeated.

But it appears there are. One Knopf writer, Charles C. Mann (co-author, with Mark L. Plummer, of "The Aspirin Wars"), says that he had his jacket photo rejected by the publisher. It showed him in an open-necked shirt. An editor (not Ms. Wilson) told him that serious nonfiction authors wear coats and ties and that they button their shirts to the top. His seriousness in doubt, Mr. Mann complied. "I would happily wear a coat and tie for my publisher," he said loyally.

Houghton Mifflin's editor in chief, John Sterling, confesses that there are indeed some unwritten yet very firm rules. These rules appear to forbid subtlety at any cost. For example, on "The New Russians," Hedrick Smith poses in front of the Kremlin. If he were standing in front of the Tilt-a-Whirl at Asbury Park, I suppose we might doubt the validity of his research. "The investigative political writer should look tough," says Mr. Sterling. "He dresses in a coat and tie, preferably in front of the Capitol." (We assume Mr. Sterling didn't mean that quite the way he said it.) "The commercial fiction writer, on the other hand, has a soft 'Vaseline' type of portrait," explains Mr. Sterling. "Maybe we should mix and match. How about a 'Vaseline shot' of a serious journalist?" Perhaps a nice soft-focus portrait of Seymour Hersh with a poodle in his lap. Or George Plimpton holding a football. (No, wait. He already did that on "Paper Lion.")

"Backlit women with big hair" is how Gerald Howard, an editor at W.W. Norton, refers to the authors of commercial romantic fiction, the ones who get the Vaseline treatment. "The woman writer of shopping-and-fornicating fiction," Mr. Howard explained, "has to project the feeling that she shops in only the most expensive stores and sleeps with only the most expensive men." Mr. Howard

bemoaned the lack of fresh cliches, noting that a couple of old standbys have disappeared. "The pipe and tweed jacket are gone," he said. "Outdoor shots are still popular, but now you have to look sensitive. You can't look like you just killed an animal. Maybe you just photographed it." No doubt with its chin on its paw. "It's the 90's," he concluded. "The trend is that there are no trends. We're beyond trends!"

Not quite. One trend that remains fashionable is making fun of the "backlit women with big hair" -- those female writers (Judith Krantz, Danielle Steel, Barbara Taylor Bradford, Jackie Collins, Jean Auel, Marianne Williamson, et al.) who sell blimp-hangar-loads of books. Editors and publishers who find such stars missing from their catalogues act as if this were by design, as if they considered it uncouth to move large amounts of product. Backlit authors are distinguished by, among other things, a proclivity toward full-color, full-page portraits on the jacket. Today there appears to be a movement toward color and size for non-big-hair authors as well. Mr. Sterling has noted the emergence of this trend over the past three or four years. "Why are so many authors in color, full page?" he asks. "Reaching for a broader audience?" Will Judith Krantz's readers start picking up Robert Stone's books by mistake?

MR. STONE is a good example of jacket portrait evolution. A rather scruffy writer looks out at us from 1981's novel "A Flag for Sunrise." In 1986's "Children of Light," he's well scrubbed, beard neatly trimmed. In last year's "Outer bridge Reach," published by Ticknor & Fields, a division of Houghton Mifflin, he looks like a made-for-TV-movie version of himself -- a prosperous bourgeois countenance with luxurious beard, all at the helm of a shiny and very expensive yacht. "It's not his boat," admits the photographer, Michael A. Smith. "I'm not sure he even owns a boat." Houghton Mifflin assured me Mr. Stone loved the shot, which is in full color and fills the entire back cover, but was unable to locate the author for an interview, saying he was "out of the country." The next morning

I ran into his son-in-law at breakfast, who said that he had just talked to Mr. Stone at his home in Connecticut. Eight weeks later his publisher still hadn't found the author. Presumably, he's lost at sea. Without a boat.

Mr. Smith admits that he committed a cliché by having water in the background. "We needed someplace to put the boat," he explains. The photograph was taken in November, not good sailing weather off Connecticut, and he and Mr. Stone just drove to a nearby marina and scampered onto a likely-looking ship. The book is about a middle-aged man who tries to sail around the world and goes nuts instead. Irene Williams, Houghton Mifflin's head of publicity, said the plan was to go for a *mise en scene* kind of photo. As for the big-hair, full-color, full-page treatment, Ms. Williams retorted: "No one will ever mistake Robert Stone for Judith Krantz." Not with that beard.

Many other unlikely authors have also gone to big full-color photos. Scott Turow, the up-market mystery writer lawyer, grins frighteningly from the back cover of "Pleading Guilty." You can see his pores. You don't want to. On the cover of "The Client" John Grisham, the Jacoby & Meyers version of Mr. Turow, sports a three-day-plus growth à la Don Johnson in his "Miami Vice" days. Mr. Grisham's most recent thriller is about a precocious 11-year-old boy who refuses to reveal a secret no matter how much legal pressure is applied to him. Mr. Grisham's editor, David Gernert, also refused to talk, but with much less flair than the average 11-year-old. He answered "I don't know" to all of our questions. Mr. Gernert, who is editor in chief at Doubleday, said he had no idea why Mr. Grisham posed that way, whether it was a conscious decision or even who at Doubleday was in charge of the dust jacket. Don't Doubleday editors oversee their own dust jackets? "I don't know," he said, but promised to find out. Six months later I still haven't heard from him. He must be off sailing with Robert Stone.

A cliché making a comeback is the author's dog, somehow always more acceptable than a cat. Two best sellers about the military service this year have portrayed their authors accompanied by bird dogs. They are very different books. Randy Shilts is shown with his golden retriever on the cover of "Conduct Unbecoming" and Gen. H. Norman Schwarzkopf with a labrador retriever on "It Doesn't Take a Hero." Mr. Shilts says he got tired of putting his chin in his hand. He endured 40 photo sessions while publicizing his previous book, "And the Band Played On," and claims every photographer made him do "The Thinker" routine. He had to use subterfuge to get Dash (the dog is named after Dashiell Hammett) onto the jacket. When his publicist at St. Martin's complained about the portrait (not serious enough), Mr. Shilts begged off a second photo session by explaining that he had to go into the hospital to be treated for AIDS. The publisher decided not to press the issue. Mr. Shilts said he needed the dog to soften his image: "I looked angry in past photos." Dash has also helped him deal with AIDS. "A dog helps pull you through," he said. "A dog offers absolute unconditional love."

Bantam Books' executive art director, Jim Ploumeri, also chose a dog picture for the purpose of softening an author's image. In the case of General Schwarzkopf, Mr. Ploumeri felt that the black lab, now deceased, helped "to take away from the heroic military side of the general." Of course, the front cover photo of General Schwarzkopf saluting is far more famous, in that two different jackets were used -- right and left sides of the face -- with two sets of books displayed side by side to show General Schwarzkopf's entire face almost full size. (The actual books themselves, of course, are identical.) General Schwarzkopf's publicist at Bantam, Stuart Applebaum, said that many people at in-store signing sessions bought both left- and right-face versions of the jacket so that they could have the entire Schwarzkopf physiognomy. Mr. Ploumeri was nervous about getting the two covers to come together properly, having been informed by the binder that dust jackets can slip an eighth of an inch horizontally in either direction. If both covers crept outward, the general would

have an enormous nose. If inward, fretted Mr. Ploumeri, "We'd have a general with one nostril." Unlike most Hollywood stars, General Schwarzkopf is probably the first celebrity to have a public referendum on which is his best side, based on cash book sales. "His right side was favored overwhelmingly," says Mr. Applebaum. "That's his salute side," points out Mr. Ploumeri.

Other cliches hang on. With the advent of computers, the typewriter is missing from most modern author photos, but there are exceptions. Danielle Steel hovers businesslike over an old-fashioned Olivetti on "Message From Nam." It's the actual typewriter, we've been assured, that she uses to pump out an average of three novels every two years. The typewriter is polished to perfection, like a classic hot rod. You can almost see the smoke coming off the keys. On the cover of "Generation of Swine," Hunter S. Thompson takes aim at his typewriter, stranded helplessly in the snow, with some variety of large handgun.

There are actually reasons for some of the cliches. I had always assumed that the chin-in-hand position was inspired by Auguste Rodin. "We photographers aren't that smart," says Mr. Lange. "The pose probably goes back to the days when exposure times for film were very long. It was a way to steady the subject's head." Mr. Lange says that it's also a good way to hide the "sensitive landscape beneath the chin." The neck is a weak point in older people, he says. "But it's not a young person's pose." And, he explains, there are other solutions. During a shoot Mr. Lange once straddled Carol Channing, shooting downward, "Blow-Up"-style, while she lay on her back. "Gravity does wonderful things for my face," she told him.

His colleague Mike Smith defends the bookcase as a prop. "Authors are 38-minute friends," he says. They don't have much time to give the photographer. "You have to establish rapport in less than an hour. So you put them in a comfortable situation. Often that's their study." And that means bookcases.

Joyce Ravid, a photographer who shoots authors for Knopf, Viking and others, believes the cat ban should be lifted, that it's a legitimate cliché. "It's the only time that an author's cat gets to go public." Now there's a book for them. "The Cat on My Shoulder: Writers and Their Cats," edited by Lisa Angowski-Rogak, sticks all those awful author-plus-cat photos in one volume and features such literary pet owners as Susan Brownmiller, Joyce Carol Oates, Sue Grafton and Bobbie Ann Mason.

The last time I had to provide an author photo, I mailed in the most flattering I could find. It was taken in 1971, when I was many pounds lighter and obviously many years younger. The publisher still decided to go without an author photo. Several months later, when I asked my editor to return the portrait, he said, "You mean you wanted that back?" I suspect many writers find themselves in the same predicament. Ugly is too strong a word. Accurate perhaps, but too strong. Joyce Ravid prefers "photogenically impaired."

THEN there are those who have too much to work with. Patrice Adcroft is a nonphotogenically impaired author whose first novel, "Every Day Doughnuts," is based on real-life adventures in a northeastern Pennsylvania Krispy Kreme doughnut shop owned by her family for many years. St. Martin's wanted the typical deb-in-heat photograph now de rigueur for young female novelists. Editors we talked to cited the preppy-but-sultry portraits of Susan Minot as the leading exemplars of this genre, but Ms. Adcroft felt that a writer's life is much grimmer than Ms. Minot's photos suggest, so she posed herself in the kitchen of her West Village apartment, which, as it turns out, she has set up like the doughnut shop her parents own in Scranton. The stools and doughnut shelf are all original Krispy Kreme vintage. She is surrounded by doughnuts -- plain, peanut and chocolate. She's got her head sideways, resting on the shelf full of crullers, "as many a waitress without a hairnet has done," she explains. Her face

is puffy. "I was having a bad yeast day." But like Mr. Stone's yacht, the doughnuts are phony. "They're not Krispy Kremes," Ms. Adcroft admitted. "I bought them at Sloan's in the Village. My customers back in Scranton complained."

Considerably more challenging to publishers is Thomas Pynchon. We asked his longtime editor, Cork Smith, what one does about Mr. Pynchon's jacket photo. "You don't do a damn thing," replied Mr. Smith, now editor in chief at Harcourt Brace. The last known portrait of Mr. Pynchon was taken for his college yearbook. But when Mr. Smith edited "V" 30 years ago for Lippincott, he had no idea about the author's mania for privacy. When Time magazine called for a photo, Mr. Smith discovered he didn't have one, so he gave the magazine Mr. Pynchon's current address, which was a rundown rooming house in Mexico City. The photographer went to Mr. Pynchon's room and found a man sitting on the bed who told him Mr. Pynchon would be back by 5 P.M. When the photographer returned, the room had been vacated. Despite his camera-shyness, Mr. Pynchon has achieved big-hair, full-page status. The back cover of his most recent book, "Vineland," has been left blank, no doubt signifying how big his photo would have been had he allowed it to be taken. "The man's a publicist's dream," Mr. Smith says.

Perhaps writers have no awareness of their bodies in space and time and just naturally look awkward in front of the camera. Maybe "awkward" is too strong a word. Joyce Ravid calls such subjects "disadvantaged posers."

YOU'D expect a wonderful portrait of a woman as striking as Susan Sontag, the acclaimed author of "On Photography," no less. How can you miss when the photographer is none other than Annie Leibovitz? Somehow, they do. Ms. Sontag is shown, on "The Volcano Lover," stretched out on her back. Her arms appear to be flailing about her head, as if she were fending off an attacker.

Perhaps intellectuals are supposed to look bad, to promote the idea that their verbal intelligence takes up the entire cerebral cortex. No brain cells are devoted to posing. One of the leading publishers of intellectual books, Peter Edidin, editor of New Republic/Basic Books, agrees: "We specialize in making people look bad here. It's our selling point. Everyone looks like a physics teacher circa 1952."

One Basic Books author, the New Yorker writer Jeremy Bernstein, attempted to look like something more than a physics teacher (which, in fact, he is) on the cover of his essay collection "Cranks, Quarks, and the Cosmos." In a large color photo, he's posed high in the mountains above Zermatt, Switzerland, with the Matterhorn in the background. It's a pretty scene, but Mr. Bernstein looks in great pain. "I was in great pain," he said. Mr. Bernstein, who's terribly myopic, said that he cannot function in the mountains without his dark glasses, which the photographer asked him to remove. The sun nearly blinded him. "I wasn't having a great day skiing either."

Joyce Ravid disagrees with the idea that writers can't pose or don't possess the requisite physical equipment for a good photo. The main problem, she says, is the "squishy little space" that publishers normally allow on the jacket for the author portrait. She suggests filling the endpapers with photos. Mike Smith says, "Authors are reluctant posers. They want to separate themselves from their books." Cork Smith claims that Mr. Pynchon's refusal to sit for a photo or do publicity of any sort doesn't stem from a hatred of the press but is simply an attempt to focus all of the attention on his books rather than on their author.

The novelist Terry McMillan talked her publisher out of running a portrait of her taking up the entire back cover of "Waiting to Exhale." "I wanted people to be interested in the book, not me," she says. Viking relented, and reduced the size of the picture. Ms. McMillan was relieved. When she first saw the original full-sized portrait, she thought, "Well, who's this bitch?"

Howard Gersten has owned and operated the Jeffery Amherst Bookshop in my little town here in western Massachusetts for the past 15 years. A former marketing executive for Bristol-Myers, Lever Brothers and Mennen, he makes bookselling sound easy. "People in Amherst buy books before they buy food," he claims. I envy Mr. Gersten his accomplishments. Unlike me, he has actually found and talked to Robert Stone. Had him right there in the store for a book signing. "Did he come by boat?" I asked.

But he disagrees with Ms. McMillan, saying it is authors like her who are changing, in a literal sense, the face of publishing. " 'Waiting to Exhale' was the most unusual book I've ever read," Mr. Gersten said. He noted that it is the first book about African-Americans that he's read that treats them like ordinary people rather than as mere victims of a white society. "I wanted to see what this author looked like."

Mr. Gersten said the biggest change he's seen in publishing in recent years is the people writing the books. "Today there are so many women, so many black writers, and more black readers. There are more Hispanic writers, a wider diversity of ethnic and racial backgrounds of authors. You want to see the person." Jacket photos, if nothing else, have chronicled this revolution. "We live in an age when everybody's a star," says Mr. Gersten. Jacket photos are a necessity. But do they necessarily have to be bad?

Mr. Gersten and I finally found a good author portrait. It was of a local writer, one whose house is but a quarter of a mile down Main Street from the bookshop. The portrait shows a rather plain woman, her hair parted in the middle, staring out at the reader. She has a hand resting on a small table. On the table is a single book. But there is no bookcase, no water, no trees and her chin is unsupported, despite the long exposure times of her era. In the book Emily Dickinson writes:

Portraits are to daily faces

As an Evening West,

To a fine, pedantic sunshine --

In a satin Vest!

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